# Berea's Outcomes-Based Assessment Process

Academic & Student Support Services

Berea's outcomes assessment process is a comprehensive, three-year cycle of assessment that helps to ensure that all areas of the college adhere to good assessment practices for continuous improvement while also fulfilling our obligations to SACSCOC and other external accrediting agencies. By the end of a three-year assessment cycle, Academic and Student Support Services (hereafter simply referred to as "programs") will need to demonstrate that they have assessed all their outcomes/objectives at least once and used the results of their assessments for improvements wherever such opportunities are found. This document provides an overview of the process for conducting meaningful and systematic outcomes-based assessment. The process is broken down into two categories of requirements – standing (or long-term) requirements and annual reporting requirements. Each of these are described below.

## Standing Requirements

- ***Program Objectives/Outcomes***
  Each academic and student support program is responsible for identifying between four to eight clear and measurable program objectives (aka "learning objectives") that describe specific and measurable achievements that result from programming, events, or other structured activities offered or performed by that program. In cases where multiple but separate programs are housed within the same center, a separate set of objectives may be offered by each program if they choose. programs are also expected to publish their objectives in the College Catalog and are strongly encouraged to also publish them on their program's web page.

## Required Annual Assessment Summary Reports (Comprised of 5 Parts):

***Part A. Assessment History & Rationale***

Before beginning the current year's assessment activities, programs must first document their assessment history for each objective/outcome being assessed. This section requires programs to provide context about previous assessment efforts and establishes the foundation for "closing the loop" in the assessment process.

For each objective/outcome selected for assessment in the current year, programs should respond to three key questions:

1. When was this objective/outcome last assessed? Programs should identify the specific academic year when the objective was previously evaluated.
2. What did the previous results indicate? Programs should summarize the key findings from the prior assessment, including whether targets/benchmarks were met and what the data revealed about achievement of the objective/outcome.
3. What actions were taken in response to those results? Programs should describe any specific changes, improvements, or interventions that were implemented based on the previous assessment findings.

If an objective/outcome has never been assessed before, programs should simply indicate this is the first assessment of that particular objective and proceed directly to Part B.

This section reinforces the principle that assessment should be a continuation of prior efforts, not a fresh start each year. By documenting assessment history, programs demonstrate their commitment to continuous improvement and provide the necessary context for interpreting current year results in light

of past performance and interventions. This approach ensures that assessment becomes a meaningful tool for ongoing program enhancement rather than an isolated annual exercise.

***Part B. Measure(s) & Methods of Assessment***

For each objective/outcome selected to be assessed in a given year, a center/program should lay out a detailed plan for how it intends to assess each of those objectives. For example, you should mention when an assessment is expected take place, who is responsible for carrying out the assessment, and how the assessment will be conducted (e.g., conducting a follow-up survey/assessment immediately after a program/event, collection of institutional data, etc.) The point is to provide as complete and accurate an understanding of the nature and appropriateness of this evidence for the objective/outcome being assessed. Remember to always include (uploaded as attachments and/or links) any supporting materials (e.g., rubrics, surveys, institutional data, etc.) that are being used for the assessment of each objective.

The report also includes, for each objective, a pre-determined target/benchmark that describes the minimum level at which the program wants to see the respective objective/outcome achieved. While targets/benchmarks should reflect a minimum ideal standard, it is up to each program to determine what the actual reasonable target/benchmark is for each of its objectives.

***Part C. Findings/Results***

For this final part of the Annual Summary Report, programs are asked to report on the results of their assessments described in the assessment plan (Part 1). Information in Part 2 includes a full description of the results of your assessment, including any supporting data/tables/graphs /illustrations/etc. Supporting material should be uploaded as separate documents and programs should make sure that they are correctly referenced in the narratives of the Summary Report.

A critical element of the Summary Report is for centers/programs to describe how they used (or intend to use) the results of their assessment in ways that enhance or increase their capacity to fulfill their mission and support student learning. Finally, if programs intend to make any changes in response to their results, they should try to describe how and when those changes might be reassessed to determine any impact those changes may have had.

***Part D. Findings/Results***

For this final part of the Annual Summary Report, programs are asked to report on how the results of their assessments described in Part B are being used to make improvements in the respective objective/outcome. If results suggest that the objective/outcome is being achieved at or above the desired target, the program simply notes that the outcome will continue to be monitored and reassessed at its next regular interval. However, if the objective/outcome does not appear to be meeting the desired target, the program is expected to describe at least one change it will make to try to better achieve that target. As part of this narrative, the program should identify when it expects to implement the change AND when it plans to reassess that objective/outcome to see if the change had the desired effect.

***Part E. List of Supporting Materials/Documentation***

Programs are required to submit all supporting materials referenced in their assessment report. Supporting materials may include rubrics, survey instruments, spreadsheets, flyers, tables,

figures, or any other documentation that provides evidence for the assessment process and findings.

To streamline the submission process, programs are strongly encouraged to consolidate all materials into a single document using one of two methods:

1. **Direct embedding**: Insert supporting materials directly into the assessment report template at the appropriate locations or at the end of the document.
2. **PDF compilation**: Save the completed assessment report template as a PDF document and append all supporting materials to the end of that PDF file.

This approach ensures that all assessment documentation is contained within a single, comprehensive file, making it easier for programs to organize their materials and for reviewers to access all relevant information. Programs should clearly reference each supporting material within the narrative sections of their report and ensure that all materials are properly labeled and organized for easy navigation.

Again, each narrative should include any supporting data/tables/graphs /illustrations/etc. as attachments (either as separate documents or embedded at the end of the Annual Summary Report, itself.

*The completed Annual Summary Report is submitted by programs at the end of every academic year (August 1st unless otherwise specified).*